

Readings

The Atheist Prays

From - A Spiritual Guide for Navigating Adulthood

By Kayla Parker

I am praying again
and how does one pray
when unsure if anything hears?

In the world I know as reliable and finite
when time and matter cycle back and forth
and I understand the answers to so many puzzles
there are moments when knowing is nothing
and I
this accumulation of systems, histories
repetitions falls from me—
how does one who is sure there is nothing
pray?

I
dark gathered around my eyes
sit in this room cluttered with my certainties
asking
my one unanswered question
holding myself perfectly still to listen
fixing my gaze
just here

wondering.

Sending Insight

Nothing else matters much -
Not wealth, nor learning, nor even health -
without this gift:
The spiritual capacity to
keep Zest in our living
Rev. Shelley Dugan

This is the creed of creed's,
the final deposit of all
humanity's important faiths:

That we should be able to believe in life.

Harry Emerson Fossick, adapted

What Don't You Believe In?

As a chaplain, whenever people tell me they are interested in finding a place to worship, I always encourage them to go church shopping. They should try a number of different churches, and if they find one they like, they should go to a few different services there before they commit. It might be that a place they really like might have had a guest speaker that day and it will feel very different the next time they go and the senior pastor leads the service. It's good to shop around!

I also remind them that choosing a church is not necessarily forever. This might be the place that fits you for right now. There are lots and lots of options. Did you know there are approximately 45,000 different Christian denominations? Every one of them has their own peculiarities and special beliefs and traditions. It's helpful to understand some of the broad categories, such as Protestant and Catholic, mainline and Evangelical. In recent years, Non-denominational moved from the fringes to become a thing. In truth, it has actually become its own denomination! There are creedal churches and covenant congregations. Unitarian Universalism is based on a covenant rather than a creed.

It's helpful to understand that there are different types of spiritualities in addition to all the different religions and denominations. Several years ago I preached about the four types of spirituality: head or intellectual spirituality, heart or emotional spirituality, feet or action and social justice spirituality, and contemplative, ritualistic spirituality. If you have a sense of what feeds your own soul, you have a better chance of finding a place that matches. If you express your faith by participating in bicycle fundraisers and serving in soup kitchens, if your innermost self is about doing work to benefit others, and you end up in a contemplative church, it's easy to think somehow there's something wrong with you, or that there's something wrong with them. There's nothing wrong. You just need to find the place that aligns with your truest self.

With all the variables involved in finding the right place to join a community and live out one's beliefs, it is interesting to note that there are also a lot of differences among those who don't believe.

In the last 30 years, the number of people who do not belong to a religious community has been substantially growing. According to Pew Research, "Today, about 28% of U.S. adults are religiously unaffiliated,

describing themselves as atheists, agnostics or 'in particular' when asked about their religion." These folks have been given the nickname "The Nones." That's N-o-n-e-s, not to be confused with befuddled Catholic sisters in wimples and habits!

The Nones are not a singular group. While they share some similarities, they also have many variances.

"Surveys have consistently shown that many Americans view religion's declining influence in society as a bad thing. "Nones" tend to vote less often, do less volunteer work in their communities and follow public affairs at lower rates than religiously affiliated people do.

"But the latest data shows that on a variety of measures, lower rates of civic engagement are concentrated among 'nones' whose religion is 'nothing in particular.' Atheists and agnostics tend to participate in civic life at rates matching or exceeding religiously affiliated people. ...

"In the latest data, 17% of "nones" identify as atheist, 20% say they are agnostic and 63% choose "nothing in particular. Atheists and agnostics, on average, have more education than religiously affiliated Americans. By contrast, people who describe their religion as 'nothing in particular' tend to have lower levels of educational attainment than religiously affiliated U.S. adults."

Over 70% of Nones say they believe in some sort of God or higher power. They don't believe in the god of the Bible. 29% of Nones say that there is no God or spiritual force in the universe.

The majority of Nones believe that spirituality is important to them. They are "spiritual, but not religious." For the most part, the Nones also have a higher regard for science than religiously affiliated people do.

The word "Agnostic" comes from the Greek "a, meaning without, and gnosis, meaning knowledge." It carries the idea that one can not know if there is a God. Equally, one can not know that God does not exist. This is beyond our knowledge.

The word "Atheist" is made up of three parts. The prefix a-, which means "without", and the root theos, which means "god". The suffix -ist indicates a person who holds certain beliefs. Essentially one who believes that God does not exist.

The American Atheists put a finer point on this definition. To say that there is no God demonstrates the influence of monotheism. However, the concern is not with God, but with the plural, gods. Gods do not exist. Further, *"Atheism is not a disbelief in gods or a denial of gods; it is a lack of belief in gods."*

"Agnosticism isn't just a "weaker" version of being an atheist... It answers a different question. Agnosticism is about what you know, or can not know.... Atheism is about what you believe.... If you lack an active belief in a god or gods, you are an atheist."

"When the American Atheists group formed in 1963, they chose the atomic whirl as a symbol of science and a symbol of atheism. The symbol demonstrates that only through the use of scientific analysis and free, open inquiry can humankind reach out for a better life. The center orbital in the symbol is broken, or open-ended. This is an acknowledgement that science is ever changing; not all of the answers are in. With new knowledge comes new questions and new areas for research and exploration."

The American Atheists even have a flag. It is a rectangle with a light blue background and a slightly-tilted red A in the center." (American Atheists - adapted) As humans, we like our group logos and flags!

When you think about atheism, what comes to your mind? Would it surprise you to learn that one study suggests that there are at least six different types of non-believers? Christopher Silver and Thomas Coleman at the University of Tennessee at Chattanooga found that there is a range from the vocally anti-religious activists to nonbelievers who still observe some religious traditions.

After doing many interviews with self-identifying non-believers, the researchers began to code their findings. They acknowledge that this is not a complete and final list, and people may find that they do not fit neatly into only one category. Still, the study is a good start into the diversity of not believing.

Silver and Coleman have listed their categories as follows:

1) Intellectual atheist/agnostic: This type of nonbeliever seeks information and intellectual stimulation about atheism. They like debating and arguing, particularly in groups and on popular internet sites. They're also well-versed in books and articles about religion and atheism, and prone to citing those works frequently.

2) *Activist:* These kinds of atheists and agnostics are not content with just disbelieving in God; they want to tell others why they reject religion and why society would be better off if we all did likewise. They tend to be vocal about political causes like gay rights, feminism, the environment and the care of animals.

3) *Seeker-agnostic:* This group is made up of people who are unsure about the existence of a God but keep an open mind and recognize the limits of human knowledge and experience. Silver and Coleman describe this group as people who regularly question their own beliefs and "do not hold a firm ideological position. That doesn't mean this group is confused, the researchers say. They just embrace uncertainty.

4) *Anti-theist:* This group regularly speaks out against religion and religious beliefs, usually by positioning themselves as "diametrically opposed to religious ideology. Anti-theists view religion as ignorance and see any individual or institution associated with it as backward and socially detrimental. The Anti-Theist has a clear and – in their view, superior – understanding of the limitations and danger of religions." Anti-theists are outspoken, devoted and – at times – confrontational about their disbelief. They believe that "obvious fallacies in religion and belief should be aggressively addressed in some form or another.

5) *Non-theist:* The smallest group among the six are the non-theists, people who do not involve themselves with either religion or anti-religion. In many cases, this comes across as apathy or disinterest. "A Non-Theist simply does not concern him or herself with religion. Religion plays no role or issue in one's consciousness or worldview; nor does a Non-Theist have concern for the atheist or agnostic movement." Instead "They simply do not believe, and in the same right, their absence of faith means the absence of anything religious in any form in their mental space.

6) *Ritual atheist:* They don't believe in God, they don't associate with religion, and they tend to believe there is no afterlife, but the sixth type of nonbeliever still finds some of the teachings of some religious traditions useful. They see these as more or less philosophical teachings of how to live

life and achieve happiness rather than a path to transcendental liberation. For example, these individuals may participate in specific rituals, ceremonies, musical opportunities, meditation, yoga classes, or holiday traditions. For many of these nonbelievers, their adherence to ritual may stem from family traditions. For others, it's a personal connection to, or respect for, the profound symbolism" inherent within religious rituals, beliefs and ceremonies.

Prior to my involvement with Unitarian Universalism, I had only experienced atheists as folks who were anti-religious zealots. They were just as vocal about their non-belief and the need for others to follow in this line of thinking as the evangelicals I knew who were trying to convert others to believe in God the way they did. I was delighted when I first began to meet with people who didn't believe in God and yet acknowledged themselves to be deeply spiritual people.

Recently, in 2021, the chaplain group at Harvard elected an atheist chaplain to be the leader for their cohort. When the news first broke about this, many people were incensed. First, they thought that the atheist chaplain was rather an oxymoron. It's not. And they thought that the atheist chaplain might try to proselytize all of the others. He did not. Instead, this atheist chaplain, Greg Epstein, was a particularly respected member of this professional group. He had written and published the book "Good Without God." The different chaplains at Harvard knew him and trusted his integrity. They believed that he would represent the chaplain group well before administration and that he would fight for the importance of spiritual care for the students and the staff. He understood the importance of spiritual care for the religious, and for the not religious, spiritual people, as well as those who did not see themselves as spiritual at all. It says something about a person when the entire chaplain group voted for him to be their leader for at least one 2 year term and perhaps longer.

An atheist chaplain does much of what a theistic chaplain does. They provide comfort, offer a safe place to sort out thoughts and feelings, display ease in the face of ambiguity and honor the courage it takes to entertain serious questions. Trained and certified chaplains don't proselytize. They do help people make meaning out of their lives and situations, and they do it in a way that fits for their clients or patients. Certainly, people who don't

believe God can be known to exist and people who lack any belief in God, need meaning in their lives, just the same as any person who claims to believe in God.

In some ways, it's a little harder for the atheist chaplain because they do not have the pat answers that are sometimes suggested during the training for religious chaplains.

When I was in seminary, one of my UU friends did a unit of chaplaincy training. Oh, she pushed her fellow students hard. When they would role-play and she would be the patient, and they would come to see her and want to offer a prayer as a way to wrap up their meeting with a nice little bow, she would challenge them. She would ask them, "What are you going to offer me as an atheist?" She really made them think!

As a point of clarification, a person who is an atheist or agnostic can still pray. They can still feel and express gratitude and wonder. They can still believe there is something that follows this life.

They may need to do a bit more intellectual work to untangle the idea of prayer, gratitude, wonder, and an after life from the concept of a god. Still, each of those religious postures are not inherently tied to the divine.

Additionally, agnostics and atheists are not necessarily humanists. They often are, but it's not an integral part of any of those definitions. Generally speaking, a humanist is someone who looks toward humanity to bring about a better world. They postulate that if things are going to get better, we need to work toward it ourselves. We aren't doing ourselves any favors if we passively wait for God to step in and make it all better.

There are some theistic theologies that hold to this same belief. In Deism, God set up the world, wound it up, and stepped back to let it run in whatever course creation decides. In Pantheism and Panentheism, God is a part of everyone and everything, but not a separate being that will ultimately swoop in and deliver the world from disaster.

The humanist puts their trust in us, glorious and flawed mortals, to ultimately save our world. And of course, there are different types of humanists. Those who focus on the preeminence of the individual, their autonomy, desires, and resources could be seen as Democratic or Liberal humanist. They run into problems when people have valid but opposing views on a matter. How to determine who is right?

Those who focus on the need for the human community to come together and take care of each other fit a model that aligns with socialism. The collective matters more than the individual voice.

Evolutionary humanism is linked to the idea of survival of the fittest. Rather than avoiding conflict, those who are victorious in battles and hardship prove themselves to be the better specimens. Some have dubbed this a fascist humanism.

Now, if this isn't enough to get your head spinning, there are other ways to categorize humanist philosophy. Just to name a few: There is Literary, Renaissance, Western Culturalism, Philosophical, Secular, Modern, Religious, and Christian Humanism. There are so many different ways to be hopeful about human kind!

Since this morning I'm speaking to a congregation of Unitarian Universalists, many of you already have an understanding of religious humanists. Rather than cutting off any good that might come from religion, Religious Humanists find that there are ways community, ritual, sacred texts, and other aspects of traditional faith, can be used for their personal benefit as well as to the betterment of the rest of humankind.

It's interesting to note that humanism took off in the early 20th century. It began to lose favor after world war II. When people pulled themselves up after the war, they were face to face with not only the good people can do but also the incredible power humans have for harm and destruction. Humanity was no longer just the hope of mortals and the world. Folks recognized that just like religion, humanity is a double-edged sword.

Speaking about the war, you have probably heard the old saying that there are no atheists in foxholes. This is not true. The terror of battle and the fear of death does not lead to immediate religious conversion.

I find it to be very similar to a thought process I often run into in my role as a chaplain. You might be surprised to know how often I hear people in crisis tell me that they do not think it is possible to face this world without a belief in God. A religious person might say, "How do people who don't have Jesus deal with this? They can't!" In case you're wondering, in those situations, I do not correct them. When I am meeting with people in the

midst of a disaster, I do them no good if I take away a belief they are using to cope. Perhaps at another time we can examine this holding.

Sometimes, folks assert that people who do not have a belief in God cannot have a firm moral foundation. Again, this is a time where I have to bite my tongue! History is full of atrocities, wars and scandals associated with those who want to be seen as righteous. This idea of the necessity of faith as a basis for morality is not good thinking. It is an emotional concept.

There is one more assumption that forces me to bite the inside of my cheek and take a slow breath. This is when people declare that no one can die peacefully unless they have God. Again, these are not settings where it's my place to correct them. For many people who believe in heaven, the expectation of seeing God and their loved ones is comforting. Sadly, this declaration ignores all the other ways people can feel good and at peace at the end of their days.

A number of years ago, right after the death of my very beloved dog, I was talking to a friend of mine who believes that once we are dead, that is it. We are dead and there is nothing else. Eternal oblivion. The idea of never seeing my sweet dog again did not sit well with me, even if this also meant I wouldn't have a consciousness to know I wasn't going to see her. Then my friend offered a new idea for me. By not insisting on an after life, by not demanding that something else follows this life, we are making the statement that this is enough. – This life, as it is, is holy and complete and good enough. I could not argue with that. Her life, and the lives of all those I have loved, is enough.

While I still like the idea of an afterlife and reuniting with those who have gone before, I no longer need it. What a priceless gift from my atheist friend.

As Unitarian Universalists, we are charged with the free and responsible search for truth and meaning. That means we try on all sorts of ideas that might be uncomfortable. It means that we take a serious look at the beliefs of others, rather than just write them off. It means that within our community, we respectfully ask, and we expect to be asked, "Why do you believe that?"

It means that we also acknowledge the differences within our beliefs, the subtle and nuanced and the loud and glaring spaces between what others hold to be true. The differences matter.

Just a quick example. Have you ever gone clothes shopping with someone with different tastes? Perhaps you know that pants with pleats do not work on your body and if a jacket doesn't have at least two decent pockets, you can not be bothered. Then your friend sends you into the dressing room with a bizarre outfit and you debate about not even trying it on. Just call out that it didn't fit. But for whatever reason, you put on this so-not-you ensemble ... and it works! Ridiculously, it looks great!

Granted, this doesn't happen often. But it can and it does. So my charge to you is to pay even closer attention to the different ways people believe and in the variety of ways people don't believe. There may yet be some new ways of thinking to try on.

Amen and Amen.